



BARCELONA SPAIN

Zarzuela in Stylish Barcelona

The cuisine of Barcelona can be as phantasmagorical as its architecture by Gaudí and his fellow Modernistas. Just as La Sagrada Familia makes the viewer wonder how the architect could possibly pile on so many ornamental encrustations, Barcelona's signature fish stew, zarzuela, makes the diner wonder if there is no end to the seafood delicacies hidden in a single bowl.



It seems perfectly natural that Barcelona, a city graced with free-flowing, fanciful architecture and a lively street life, would have developed a fish stew as studded with textures, shapes, colors, and flavors as the *zarzuela de mariscos a la catalana*. How this Catalan cousin of Marseille's bouillabaisse (see pp128–9) and Provençal *soupe aux poissons* got its name is something of a mystery, but “zarzuela” is also a form of Spanish light opera that includes rustic dances, spoken dialogue, and songs. It is perhaps the similarly surprising and delightful mixture that has earned this fish stew – a veritable seafood operetta – the same name.

Spruced up for the 1992 Olympics, Barcelona nonetheless retains its character as a colorful beachfront town first settled by fishermen in 1754. The formerly disreputable shoreline district of working wharves and sailors' enticements is now an area of flourishing seafood restaurants, where Barcelonans and visitors alike go to promenade alongside a sandy beach that flows from the Olympic sports harbor to the Old Port. Here, the statue of the explorer Columbus marks the foot of the city's most famous pedestrian boulevard, La Rambla.

Barcelona springs to life along the broad, car-free expanse of La Rambla, with flower vendors, living statues, bird-sellers, newspaper kiosks, and cafés as still points in the flowing human river. Side streets branch off into the Barri Gòtic (Gothic quarter), where folk-dancers step through the *sardana* every Sunday in front of the cathedral. At the head of La Rambla, the 19th-century district of L'Eixample contains much of the city's famous Modernista architecture, including two buildings by Gaudí that are now World Heritage sites: the undulating, organic Casa Milà (“La Pedrera”) and his most famous building, the uncompleted cathedral of the Holy Family – La Sagrada Familia.

No place looks like Barcelona, and likewise Barcelona's zarzuela stands apart from other fish stews. The easy-going Catalans improvise endlessly, and cooks can add any firm fish to the garlicky broth tinged sunset-golden with saffron, as long as they also include bright shrimp, earthy small clams, pink mussels in their blue shells, a king prawn, and half a lobster. This rich dish is served in wide, shallow bowls so diners can admire the jumble of colors, inhale the rising aromas, and sop up the ocean-salty broth with garlic-rubbed toast. Like Barcelona itself, zarzuela is a feast for all the senses.

Right Gaudí worked on the still-unfinished La Sagrada Familia for more than 40 years, famously declaring that “my client is not in a hurry”



Above The Plaça Reial, a large square in the Barri Gòtic, provides an atmospheric setting for its many renowned restaurants, cafés, and bars

Below The distinctive, saffron-rich fish stew called zarzuela is a riot of warm color, as red pepper curls among the gently poached pink and white seafood



A Day in Barcelona

As the capital of Catalan culture – neither precisely Spanish nor French – Barcelona is a city of rich artistic ferment. Joan Miró was born here, Pablo Picasso spent his formative years here, and Antoni Gaudí became the city's most famous architect, bequeathing it the iconic Sagrada Familia and a range of other Modernista masterpieces.

MORNING See a masterpiece nearing completion as the morning light strikes the spires of **La Sagrada Familia**. Then visit **Casa Milà**, Gaudí's finished crowning glory.

AFTERNOON Stroll through the circus-like scene of **La Rambla**, veering into the quieter **Barri Gòtic** to visit the **Museu Picasso**, repository of the artist's earliest works. Take the cable car up to **Montjuïc**, where the organic building designed by architect Josep Lluís Sert showcases the surrealism of Miró's paintings and sculptures.

EVENING As evening falls, stroll the **waterfront promenade** and enjoy tapas, then dinner, at the bars and restaurants of Barceloneta, the 18th-century waterfront district.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Barcelona's **international airport**, El Prat de Llobregat, lies 8 miles (13 km) from the downtown, and has connecting **trains** and **buses**.

WHERE TO STAY

El Jardí Hotel (inexpensive) has bright rooms in the old town. www.hoteljardi-barcelona.com

Hotel Casa Fuster (moderate) is a historic Modernista building. www.hotelcasafuster.com

Hotel Arts Barcelona (expensive) provides luxurious comfort on Barcelona's revitalized waterfront. www.ritzcarlton.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

Plaza de Catalunya; www.barcelonaturisme.com

La Boqueria Food Market

There has been a fresh food market on La Rambla since 1701, although the current incarnation of the Mercat de La Boqueria – which resembles a Modernista train shed with its soaring steel roof – dates from 1914. If La Sagrada Familia expresses Barcelona's faith, La Boqueria expresses the city's obsession with good food. More than 300 stalls and dozens of mini-restaurants, cafés, and bars make up the market, which is among the largest in Europe. The fishmongers, their catch heaped on ice, fill the center, and butchers, fruit and vegetable sellers, and preserved-food dealers radiate outward. From wild mushrooms to baby squid, if Catalans eat it, someone in La Boqueria sells it.